Poem of Gilgameš – Old Babylonian Nippur: “‘My Friend, We Have Come Close To The Forest”

- Source: eBL corpus – https://www.ebl.lmu.de/corpus/L/1/4/Old%20Babylonian/Nippur
- API: https://www.ebl.lmu.de/api/texts/L/1/4/chapters/Old%20Babylonian/Nippur/display
- Edition: Andrew R. George (editor); Geraldina Rozzi (revision); Enrique Jiménez (revision)
- Translation: Andrew R. George
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Per line: **N** = normalized Akkadian reconstruction (`|` metrical foot, `||` caesura); **T** = eBL English translation; **L** = lemmas with eBL dictionary glosses; then notes, parallel lines, and the manuscripts' transliterations (ATF). Bibliography keys like [RN117: 889] are resolved in `bibliography.md` (RN117 = George 2003).

1

- **N:** ibrī | niqterib | qištiš
- **T:** ‘My friend, we have come close to the forest,
- **L:** *ibrī* ← ibru I “friend, colleague”; *niqterib* ← qerēbu I “to be/come close”; *qištiš* ← qištu I “pl. *qišātu(m)* forest, wood *q. erēnim* cedar forest”

```
NipOB1 o 1. ib-ri ni-iq-te-ri-ib qi₂-iš-ti-iš
```

2

- **N:** šun[ātu]m | qitrubā || aruh | tāhāzum
- **T:** (what was foretold in) dreams is near at hand, battle is swift (upon us).
- **L:** *šun[ātu]m* ← šuttu I “pl. *šunātu(m)* dream *š. naṭālu*, *amāru* etc. to have a dream, to...”; *qitrubā* ← qerēbu I “to be/come close”; *aruh* ← arāhu I “to hasten O/jB”; *tāhāzum* ← tāhāzu I “pl. f. battle”

```
NipOB1 o 2. šu-n[a-tu]m qi₃#-it-ru-ba a-ru-uh ta-ha-zu-um
```

3

- **N:** namrīrī | ša ilim | tanaṭṭal
- **T:** You will see the radiant auras of the god,

- **L:** *namrīrī* ← namrīru I “awe-inspiring radiance OAkk, Bab.(lit.)”; *ša* ← ša I “who(m), which”; *ilim* ← ilu I “pl. *ilū*, *ilānu* god, deity a or the god, also du.”; *tanaṭṭal* ← naṭālu I “to look”
- **Parallels:** cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen$_3$" b+4'

```
NipOB1 o 3. nam-ri#-ri# ša i-lim ta-na-ṭa-a-al
```

4

- **N:** huwāwa | ša ittanandaru | kabtatka
- **T:** of Ḫuwawa, whom your mind does ever fear.
- **L:** *huwāwa* ← Humbaba I; *ša* ← ša I “who(m), which”; *ittanandaru* ← adāru II “to be afraid (of), fear”; *kabtatka* ← kabattu I “liver, also innards”

```
NipOB1 o 4. hu-wa-wa ša i-ta-na-an-da-ru ka-ab-ta-at-ka
```

5

- **N:** attā | tattakkip-ma || kīma lēʾim | tušabraqšu
- **T:** You will lock horns and batter him like a bull,
- **L:** *attā* ← attā I “you (2 m. sg. pron.)”; *tattakkip-ma* ← nakāpu I “to push, thrust Bab., NA”; *kīma* ← kīma I “like”; *lēʾim* ← lī'u I “bull O/jB offered, slain, eaten”; *tušabraqšu* ← barāqu I “to lighten, shine Bab.(lit.)”
- **Note:** See [RN117: 244]: “The line divides into two equal halves, with a pause at the caesura: *átta* | *tattakkípma* || *kīma léʾim* | *tušabráqšu*. The bull belongs with the second verb. Renger read *tušaprakšu* and translated ‘als war er ein Ringer, wirst [Du] ihm (den Hals) zur Seite drehen’; this is perhaps reading too much into *šupruku*, ‘to put in the way’. Hecker follows Renger but I side with Bottéro, Tournay and Shaffer, who render the clause ‘tu l’abattras comme un taureau’. The bull develops the imagery of the first part of the line in a way that a wrestler would not. The causative stem of *barāqu* is used figuratively for violent destruction of an enemy: see the passages quoted in *CAD* B, p. 104, 2 c, and note *Malku* I 107: *šub-ru-qu* = *da-a-ku*, ‘to kill’ ([temp_id_2401129561684543: 426]).”

```
NipOB1 o 5-6. at-ta ta-at-ta-ak-ki-ip-ma ki-ma le-i-im | ($___$) tu-ša-ab-ra-aq-
```

6

- **N:** rēšīšu | tušappal | ina dannūtīka
- **T:** you will force his head down with your strength.
- **L:** *rēšīšu* ← rēšu I “head”; *tušappal* ← šapālu I “to be(come) deep, low”; *ina* ← ina I “(*im-m...*, *ip-p...* etc.) in, on”; *dannūtīka* ← dannūtu I “strength, power Ass., O/jB”

- **Note:** See [RN117: 244]: “The significance of forcing the bull’s head down (flat on the ground?) is probably that this is how a bull-wrestler breaks a bull’s neck. Contra Hecker, *TUAT* III/4, p. 661, fn. 6a, *rēšīšu* is not plural but dual, as often.”

```
NipOB1 o 7. re-ši#-šu tu-ša-ap-pa-al i-na da-an-nu-ti-ka
```

7

- **N:** puršumum | ša tāmuru || ilka | wīru(m)
- **T:** The old man you saw is your mighty god,
- **L:** *puršumum* ← puršumu I “old (man) O/jB, NA”; *ša* ← ša I “who(m), which”; *tāmuru* ← amāru I “to see”; *ilka* ← ilu I “pl. *ilū*, *ilānu* god, deity a or the god, also du.”; *wīru(m)* ← īru I “~ strong jB lex.”
- **Note:** See [RN117: 244–245]: “Others have taken *wi-ru* as the god Wēr, though Renger and Bottéro drew attention to the problem such an interpretation posed with regard to the Yale tablet, where Wēr is the guardian of the Cedar Forest and thus an ally of Gilgameš’s enemy (OB III 131). Here, as elsewhere in the epic, Gilgameš’s god is not Wēr but Lugalbanda (see OB III 271, OB Harmal 15–16 and SB VI 165), and Wēr is thus quite out of place for this reason too. Accordingly one is led to look for a suitable adjective or common noun that can be written *wi-ru*. The existence of such a word can perhaps be supported by the lexical entry *Malku* I 52: *i-ru* = *ga-aš-ru* ([temp_id_2401129561684543: 425; also p. 435], Explicit *Malku* I 143). This adjective probably also appears in the OB text about Narām-Sîn and Erra, where Erra is described as *wi-ru-um ša-ka-al-mu-šu*, ‘mighty terror’ ([RN2008a: 361, 37; cf. note on p. 363]). The absence of mimation in our text is unusual, but note also *da-an-nu* in rev. 6'.”
- **Parallels:** cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen$_3$" b+7'

```
NipOB1 o 8. pu-ur-šu-mu-um ša ta-mu-ru-u2 il-ka we-ru
```

8

- **N:** bāni | qaqqadīka | lugalbanda
- **T:** the one who begot you, Lugalbanda.’
- **L:** *bāni* ← banû IV “to create”; *qaqqadīka* ← qaqqadu I “pl. f. head”; *lugalbanda* ← Lugalbanda I
- **Note:** See [RN117: 245]: “As W. G. Lambert tells me (private communication), the phrase *bāni qaqqadim* in the meaning ‘father, sire’ is a calque from Sumerian *sag.du$_3$* (var. *du/dug$_4$*), for which see G. R. Castellino, *Two Šulgi Hymns (BC)*, p. 181; Å. W. Sjöberg, *TCS* III, p. 54. Note especially in an inscription of Samsuiluna: *{d*nanna dingir sag.du.mu.še$_3$} : *a-na {d*EN:[ZU] DINGIR ba-ni-ia}, ‘for Sîn, the god who begot me’ (D. Frayne, *RIME* 4, p. 381, 41–2 // 39).”

```
NipOB1 o 9. ba-ni# qa₂-qa₂-di-ka {d}lugal-ban₃-da
```

9

- **N:** ibrī | ātamar | rebūtam
- **T:** ‘My friend, I have seen a fourth,
- **L:** *ibrī* ← ibru I “friend, colleague”; *ātamar* ← amāru I “to see”; *rebūtam* ← rebû I “fourth”

```
NipOB1 o 10. ib-ri a-ta-mar re-bu-ta-am
```

10

- **N:** etqet | eli šalaštin | šunātīya
- **T:** it surpasses my (other) three dreams!
- **L:** *etqet* ← etēqu I “to go past”; *eli* ← eli I “on, over, above”; *šalaštin* ← šalāš I “st. abs.”; *šunātīya* ← šuttu I “pl. *šunātu(m)* dream *š. naṭālu*, *āmāru* etc. to have a dream, to…”
- **Note:** See [RN117: 245–246]: “For a *plene* spelling comparable to *e-et-qe₃-et*, and from the same verb, see the imperative *e-et-qa₂-ni-i-ma*, ‘pass me by!’, in the OB narrative poem about Narām-Sîn and Apišal (v 7; [RN262: 182]). The form *šalaštin* compares, as Renger noted, with *erbettin* in *ki-ib-ra-a-at er-be₂-ti-in*, ‘four world-regions’, in a fragmentary OB text about Sargon of Akkade (*BRM* IV 4, 4–5, ed. [RN262: 34]). The parallel is more instructive than Renger saw, however, for the gender of the number is the same as the noun. The absence of polarity thus marks the phrase *šalaštin šunātīya* as comprising two nouns, though in apposition rather than in a possessive construction such as *kibrāt/sūq/šār erbettim*. Usual language would yield *šalāš šunātīya*. *šalaštum* is a group of three (‘triad’) comparable with *erbettum*, ‘group of four’, *ḫamiltu*, ‘group of five’, and *sebettum*, ‘heptad’. For nunation in OB see now *GAG*³ §§44c (possessive pronouns), 63c (miscellaneous).”

```
NipOB1 o 11. e-et-qe₃-et e-li ša-la-aš-ti-in šu-na-ti-ia#
```

11

- **N:** appalsam-ma | anzâm | ina šamê
- **T:** I watched an Anzû-bird in the sky,
- **L:** *appalsam-ma* ← palāsu I “to look (at)”; *anzâm* ← Anzû I “Anzû”; *ina* ← ina I “(*im-m*…, *ip-p*… etc.) in, on”; *šamê* ← šamû I “mostly pl. tant. sky, heaven”

```
NipOB1 o 12. ap#-pa-al-sa₃-am-ma {d}IM.DUGUD{mušen}-am i-na ša-ma-i
```

12

- **N:** itbē-ma | kīma erpeti || iša”u | elni

- **T:** up it rose like a cloud, soaring above us.
- **L:** *itbē-ma* ← tebû I "OAkk, Ass. *tabā'u(m)*, NB *tabû* to get up, arise, set out"; *kīma* ← kīma I "like"; *erpeti* ← erpetu I "cloud Bab. red, black etc."; *iša᾽᾽u* ← šâ'u I "to fly O/jB"; *elni* ← eli I "on, over, above"
- **Note:** See [RN117: 245–246]: "At the beginning of the line the reading *itbēma* (against Renger: *š[a] x x*), which Bottéro ('il s'élança', also Tournay and Shaffer) and Hecker ('er erhob sich') also saw, means that *i-ša-ú* is not the present subjunctive of the 'hollow' root √*šū᾽*, but the plain present of a variant II+III-Aleph root (*u/u*). As Renger noted, *šâ'u* also describes the characteristic behaviour of the mythical lion-headed eagle, the *Anzû*-bird, in an inscription of Aššurnaṣirpal II (now Grayson, *RIMA* 2, p. 260, 74). The verb seems to cover soaring, wheeling and swooping, that is, the flight pattern typical of large birds of prey. Division of the poetic line into units indicates that the simile occurs before the caesura and so belongs in the first clause not the second: *itbēma* | *kīma érpetim* || *iša᾽᾽u* | *elīni*.

```
NipOB1 o 13. it#-be₂#-ma ki#-ma er-pe-tim i-ša-u₂ el-ni
```

13

- **N:** … | šunnû | pānūša
- **T:** It was a …, its face was very strange,
- **L:** *šunnû* ← šanû IV "to be changed, become different"; *pānūša* ← pānu I "front, pl. face"
- **Note:** See [RN117: 246]: "To my eyes the traces of the first word do not allow Renger's *nap-lu-uh₂-tum-ma*, 'da war eine Schreckensgestalt', though it cannot be discounted that some of the traces on my copy are remnants of poorly erased signs. I can offer no firm decipherment, only the comment that *du!-lu!-uh₂-tum-ma*, 'there was confusion', is as likely as *napluḫtumma*, if not more so. One must also bear in mind that in the parallel line, rev. 2', the space suggests that <the> word is written more concisely, with three signs instead of four. The word *šunnû* could also be translated 'double', but here probably has implications of monstrousness (cf. Bottéro, 'son aspect était monstreux'). The face of Anzû, the lion-headed eagle, was a by-word for horror, even the very image of death, as we know from Enkidu's dream on his death-bed (MB Ur 65–6 // SB VII 168–9) and elsewhere (see the commentary on MB Ur 66)."
- **Parallels:** L I.4 OB "Nippur" a+2

```
NipOB1 o 14. x x-uh₂-tum-ma šu-un-nu-u₂ pa-nu-u₂-ša
```

14

- **N:** pīša | girrum || napīssa | mūtu[m]
- **T:** its speech was fire, its breath was death.

- **L:** *pīša* ← pû I “(also OB)”; *girrum* ← gīru I “fire(-god) O/jB as DN”; *napīssa* ← napīšu I “breath(ing) Bab.”; *mūtu[m]* ← mūtu I “death”
- **Parallels:** L I.4 OB "III" 111-112; L I.4 OB "III" 198; L I.4 OB "Nippur" a+3

```
NipOB1 o 15. pi-ša# {d#}gira₃# na-pi#-is₂#-sa# mu-tu[m]
```

15

- **N:** eṭlu[m-ma] | šani | binīta[m]
- **T:** [There was a] man, strange of form,
- **L:** *eṭlu[m-ma]* ← eṭlu I “manly”; *šani* ← šanû IV “to be changed, become different”; *binīta[m]* ← binītu I “pl. *binâtu*, OB *biniātum* creation”
- **Parallels:** cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen₂" 9; cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen₃" a+6'; cf. L I.4 MB "Boǧ₂" 15'

```
NipOB1 o 16. eṭ-lu[m-ma?] ša-ni bi#-ni#-ta#-a[m]
```

16

- **N:** [...] ... izzaz | ina mušītīya
- **T:** [he ...] and was standing there in my dream.
- **L:** *izzaz* ← izuzzu I “to stand”; *ina* ← ina I “(*im-m...*, *ip-p...* etc.) in, on”; *mušītīya* ← mušītu I “pl. *mušiātu*, *mušâtu* night(-time)”
- **Note:** Lit. ‘in my night’.

```
NipOB1 o 17. [x x x x] x-ši?#-ma?# iz-za-az i-na mu-ši-ti-ia
```

17

- **N:** [...] ... | kappīša || iṣṣabat | idī
- **T:** [He *bound*] its wings, he took hold of my arm,
- **L:** *kappīša* ← kappu I “wing O/jB of bird, ant, god, statue”; *iṣṣabat* ← ṣabātu I “to seize, take”; *idī* ← idu I “pl. m. & f. arm”
- **Note:** See [RN117: 246]: “The traces copied by Cavigneaux after *i-di* run over, as he indicates, from the reverse.”

```
NipOB1 o 18. [x x x x] x ka#-ap#-pi-ša iṣ-ṣa-ba-at i-di
```

18

- **N:** [...] ...-ma || ittadīši | [ina mah]rīya
- **T:** [...] ... and he cast it down [before] me.

- **L:** *ittadīši* ← nadû III “to throw (down)”; *[ina* ← ina I “(*im-m*..., *ip-p*... etc.) in, on”; *mah]rīya* ← mahru II “front”

```
NipOB1 o 19-20. [x x x x] x-ma it-ta-di-i-ši | ($___$) [i-na ma-ah]-ri-ia
```

19

- **N:** [...] ... elīša
- **T:** [...] ... upon it.’
- **L:** *elīša* ← eli I “on, over, above”

```
NipOB1 o 21. [...] x-gi# e-li-ša
```

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a+0

- **N:** [...]
- **N (variant, other manuscripts):** [...]
- **T:** [‘You watched an Anzû-bird in the sky,]

a+1

- **N:** i[tbē-ma | kīm]a [e]rpeti || iš[a”u] | elni
- **T:** up [it rose like a] cloud, soaring above us.
- **L:** *i[tbē-ma* ← tebû I “OAkk, Ass. *tabā'u(m)*, NB *tabû* to get up, arise, set out”; *kīm]a* ← kīma I “like”; *[e]rpeti* ← erpetu I “cloud Bab. red, black etc.”; *iš[a’u]* ← šâ'u I “to fly O/jB”; *elni* ← eli I “on, over, above”

```
NipOB1 r 1'. i[t-be₂-ma ki-m]a [e]r-p[e-ti]m | i#-š[a-u₂] el-ni
```

a+2

- **N:** [...] ...-ma | šunnû | pānūša!
- **T:** It was a [...], its face was very strange,
- **L:** *šunnû* ← šanû IV “to be changed, become different”; *pānūša!* ← pānu I “front, pl. face”
- **Parallels:** L I.4 OB "Nippur" 13

```
NipOB1 r 2'. [x x-t]um-ma šu#-nu-u₂ pa-nu-u₂-šu
```

a+3

- **N:** pīša | girrum || napīssa | mūtum
- **T:** its speech was fire, its breath was death.

- **L:** *pīša* ← pû I “(also OB)”; *girrum* ← gīru I “fire(-god) O/jB as DN”; *napīssa* ← napīšu I “breath(ing) Bab.”; *mūtum* ← mūtu I “death”
- **Parallels:** L I.4 OB "Nippur" 14

```
NipOB1 r 3'. pi#-ša# {d}gira₃# na-pi-is₂-sa mu-tum
```

a+4

- **N:** šalummassa | tapallaham | attā
- **T:** While you fear its awesome splendour,
- **L:** *šalummassa* ← šalummatu I “~ radiance Bab., Bogh., Ug. of deities, king, temple, cult…”; *tapallaham* ← palāhu I “to fear, revere”; *attā* ← attā I “you (2 m. sg. pron.)”
- **Note:** See [RN117: 246 ad 4′–5′]: “The structure of the couplet is enhanced by the opposition of *atta* and *anāku*. The first word of l. 5' remains a problem. Renger proposed derivation from *etēmum*, and translated ‘werde ich *anstoßen*’, but the meaning of this verb is very obscure. A more secure candidate is *ṭênum* (*e-ṭe₄-en*, ‘I shall mill’), but the sense leaves a lot to be desired. The unusual spelling of *ušetbēka* recalls the use of CV signs for VC in an older tradition of orthography, as for example at Ebla. On this see below, the introduction to OB Harmal₂.”

```
NipOB1 r 4'. ša!(TA)-lum-ma-sa₃ ta-pa-la-ha-am# at!-ta!
```

a+5

- **N:** … | šēpša | ušetbēka | anāku
- **T:** I shall … its foot, I shall enable you to arise!
- **L:** *šēpša* ← šēpu I “f., often du.”; *ušetbēka* ← tebû I “OAkk, Ass. *tabā'u(m)*, NB *tabû* to get up, arise, set out”; *anāku* ← anāku I “I”
- **Note:** This couplet can also be translated as reportage: ‘While you were fearing its awesome splendour, I …ed its foot, I enabled you to arise.’

```
NipOB1 r 5'. e#-TE-en ši-ip-ša! u₂-še-te-be₂-ka a-na-ku
```

a+6

- **N:** eṭlum | ša tāmuru || šamaš | dannu
- **T:** The man you saw was mighty Šamaš …’
- **L:** *eṭlum* ← eṭlu I “manly”; *ša* ← ša I “who(m), which”; *tāmuru* ← amāru I “to see”; *šamaš* ← Šamaš I; *dannu* ← dannu I “NA f. also *da''atu* strong, powerful, mighty, great of god, king,…”
- **Parallels:** cf. L I.4 OB "Harmal₁" 12; cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen₂" 21; cf. L I.4 OB "Schøyen₃" b+7'; cf. L I.4 MB "Boğ₂" 26'

```
NipOB1 r 6'. eṭ#-lum ša ta-mu-ru {d}UTU da-an-nu
```